Presentation Planning Handout

Digitalist Papers Essays — Team Selection and Preparation

ECON 470 — Microeconomics of Artificial Intelligence

Spring 2026

1 What you are doing today

You have the second half of class to plan your Digitalist Papers presentations. Use this handout to form teams, pick your essay, and block out your preparation.

By the end of class, each team should have:

1. A team of 2 (one team of 3 if needed — we have 22 students, so 11 teams of 2)
2. A chosen essay (first come, first served — no two teams on the same essay)
3. A one-page plan submitted via the sign-up sheet circulating in the room

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2 The essay menu

These are the ten suggested essays from *The Digitalist Papers*, Volume 2: *The Economics of Transformative AI* (Stanford Digital Economy Lab, 2024). Read the one-line descriptions below, skim the essays online at https://www.digitalistpapers.com/volume2, and pick the one that most interests your team.

#	Author(s)	Topic
1	Yoshua Bengio	Global catastrophic risks from AI: destructive chaos, concentration of power, loss of control
2	Avital Balwit (Anthropic)	Preparing the next generation for transformed labor markets
3	David Autor & Neil Thompson	Labor scenarios from augmentation to full displacement
4	Ioana Marinescu	Adjustment insurance and digital dividends for workers

#	Author(s)	Topic
5	Anton Korinek & Lee Lockwood	Tax systems for the age of transformative AI
6	Ajay Agrawal & Joshua Gans	TAI as a "genius supply shock" and regulatory sandboxes
7	Joseph Stiglitz & Maxim Ventura-Bolet	AI, innovation, and misinformation
8	Betsey Stevenson	Meaning, purpose, and well-being when work is displaced
9	Anna Yelizarova	Global dividend mechanisms for sharing AI prosperity
10	Susan Athey & Fiona Scott Morton	Cheap Goods for Everyone? Market power in AI and its effects on welfare

Sign-up rule: Write your team's names next to your chosen essay on the sheet at the front of the room. No duplicates.

3 Alternative essays (advanced option)

Ten Digitalist essays, eleven teams — so at least one team will need a different source. Beyond that, any team may pick from the list below instead of the Digitalist menu. These are research papers and analytical essays that sit at a higher level of technical difficulty and are appropriate for advanced economics majors who want a meatier source.

Items marked **[T]** are **more technical** — they contain formal models, empirical estimation, or industrial-organization theory and assume comfort with intermediate micro, econometrics, or growth theory. Items without the tag are conceptually advanced but readable without a technical background.

#	Source	Topic
11	Tom Cunningham — "Economics and Transformative AI"	A systematic survey of what economic theory has said (and failed to say) about TAI. Best for a team that wants to frame the *field*, not a single argument.
12 **[T]**	NBER — "The Emerging Market for Intelligence: Pricing, Supply, and Demand for LLMs"	Industrial organization of LLM markets. Pricing theory, supply curves, demand estimation. Pairs naturally as a counterpoint to Athey & Scott Morton (essay 10).

#	Source	Topic
13	"The Agentic Economy" (*Communications of the ACM*)	Argues agents, not chatbots, are the correct unit of analysis for AI's economic effects. Forward-looking and testable — a strong critique target.
14 [**T**]	Joint Economic Committee report — *Forecasting the Economic Effects of AI* (PDF in course folder)	A quantitative macro forecast. Teams evaluate the methodology: growth accounting, productivity assumptions, scenario construction. Real analytical exercise.
15 [**T**]	One paper from the NBER Economics of Transformative AI Workshop (Fall 2025)	Pick *one* paper from the workshop program at https://www.nber.org/conferences/economics-transformative-ai-workshop-fall-2025 and treat it as your source. Closest to a senior-seminar experience. Requires instructor approval of the specific paper.
16	Justin Wolfers — "A Primer on the Economics of AI" (lecture, YouTube)	Clear, opinionated macro framing from a senior economist. Good for a team that wants to compare a macro view against Gans's micro framing.
17	Tyler Cowen — "The Economics of Artificial Intelligence" (lecture, YouTube)	Distinctive and contrarian. Cowen makes claims that are genuinely fun to pressure-test.

How to sign up for an alternative: Same sheet, different column. If you pick a [**T**] essay, both teammates should confirm you are comfortable with the technical level before committing — these are harder to present well. If you pick item 15, email Professor Zambrano your chosen workshop paper before the end of the week for approval.

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4 How to pick an essay (15 minutes)

Spend about 15 minutes of class time on this. Do not pick the first essay that sounds fine — pick the one your team will be *glad* to spend two weeks on.

4.1 Individually first (5 min)

Each team member looks at the menu and writes down:

- Their **top three** essays, in order
- One sentence on **why** each one interests them
- One concept from **Chapters 3 or 4 of Gans** that the essay might connect to (value of prediction, imperfect signals, biased signals, rules vs. decisions, insurance vs. protection, AI adoption thresholds, hidden uncertainty, asymmetric stakes)

4.2 Together (10 min)

Compare lists. Find overlap. If your top choices overlap, great. If not, talk through *why* each of you ranked as you did. The goal is not compromise — it is to find the essay where both of you will contribute real ideas.

Tiebreakers when you are stuck:

- Which essay lets you make the best use of the Gans framework?
- Which one has a claim you genuinely disagree with? (Presentations are more interesting when the presenters push back.)
- Which one connects to something your team already knows — a major, a side interest, a news story you have been following?

Once you decide, one team member walks to the sign-up sheet and writes both names next to the essay number.

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5 What your presentation needs to do

You will present in Weeks 4–10. Each presentation is **20 minutes** followed by **10 minutes** of discussion that your team leads. Your job is not to summarize the essay. Your job is to *teach and critique* it.

A strong presentation does four things:

1. **Frame the question.** What problem is the author trying to solve? Why does it matter? State it in one sentence at the top of your deck.
2. **Explain the argument.** Walk through the author's logic, not just their conclusions. If they use a model, a data pattern, or a historical analogy, make it clear.
3. **Connect to course concepts.** Use the vocabulary we have built. Is the author talking about the value of prediction? Rules vs. decisions? Insurance and protection? Biased signals? Asymmetric stakes? At least *one* Gans concept should appear explicitly in your slides.
4. **Critique, don't summarize.** What is the weakest step in the argument? What assumption would you push on? What does the essay get right that your classmates should take seriously? A presentation that ends with "and so the author concludes X" is incomplete — you should end with *your* judgment.

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6 Team planning worksheet (20 minutes)

Fill this out together during class. Keep it — you will refer back to it as you prepare. One copy per team.

6.1 Team members

- Name 1: _____
- Name 2: _____
- (Name 3, if team of 3): _____

6.2 Essay chosen

- Essay number: _____
- Author(s): _____
- Title: _____
- Presentation date: _____

6.3 The one-sentence question

In one sentence, what question is this essay trying to answer?

6.4 The author's main claim

In two or three sentences, what does the author argue?

6.5 The Gans connection

Which concept(s) from Chapters 3–4 (or later chapters we have covered by your presentation date) can you use to illuminate or critique this essay?

6.6 The critique

What is one assumption, claim, or step in the argument that you are skeptical of? Why?

6.7 Division of labor

Who is doing what between now and the presentation date? Be concrete. "Read the essay" is not a task — "read the essay and write a one-page summary by Sunday" is.

Task	Who	By when

6.8 Discussion questions for the class

Write two questions you will pose to the class during the 10-minute discussion after your talk. Good discussion questions are:

- **Specific** (not "what do you think about this?")
- **Open** (not yes/no)
- **Rooted in the essay** (the class has to have read it to answer well)

Question 1:

Question 2:

7 Before you leave class today

- ☐ Team formed and both names written on this sheet
- ☐ Essay chosen and signed up on the front-of-room sheet
- ☐ Worksheet above filled in (at least the question, claim, and Gans connection)
- ☐ Division of labor decided and first task scheduled within the next week
- ☐ Both teammates have each other's preferred contact method

Hand in the filled worksheet to the folder at the front of the room on your way out. Professor Zambrano will review them and follow up by email if anything needs adjusting.

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8 A final note

The point of these presentations is not to perform — it is to *think in public* about essays that smart people wrote about a future that is uncertain. You are not expected to have the right answer. You are expected to have *read carefully*, *used the tools from this course*, and *formed a view*. Good luck.